

REGIONAL PARTIES

States of Flux

■ The Congress once embodied rainbow regionalism.

In the first general elections in 1952, while the party won 339 seats, regional parties managed just 16.

■ In 1982, the Congress ruled in 20 of the 24 states. In 2007, it has only 12 and is out of power in most big states except Andhra Pradesh. In Maharashtra and some north-eastern states, it is just a partner.

■ Regionalism was at its apex in the 1999 general elections. Twenty-eight regional parties contested, the highest ever, winning 130 seats, and the Congress got just 118, the party's lowest figure ever.

■ The regional surge in political expression is directly proportional to the fading of the Congress. In the most recent elections in 2004, it was clear the party's national stature had shrunk. Regional identities asserted themselves, so in 2004, while the Congress won 151 seats, as many as 26 regional parties won 126 seats.

translation of unity in diversity. It was a grand coalition at work. Regional, religious or caste aspirations didn't require a forum other than the Congress at its classical best. It also co-opted such regional heavyweights as Sardar Patel, Govind Ballabh Pant, D.P. Mishra, Mohan Lal Sukhadia and Pratap Singh Kairon. It was a party in which leaders and the Leader could exist in perfect harmony. It paraded veterans of caste politics like Jagjivan Ram, Kamalapati Tripathi, Narain Dutt Tiwari, Sardar Swaran Singh and K. Kamaraj.

The Congress Century, however, came to an end some time ago. What we have today is a bad parody. The party has no leaders with a regional aura. It was handicapped in the Gujarat campaign, with no powerful local leader to challenge Narendra Modi. It was left to party president Sonia Gandhi and son Rahul to mobilise the voters against Force Modi. On the other hand we have leaders like Mulayam Singh Yadav, Mayawati, Parkash Singh Badal, Farooq Abdullah, J. Jayalalithaa, M. Karunanidhi, Mamata Banerjee, H.D. Deve Gowda and Naveen Patnaik, who are the brand ambassadors of an India where the periphery is resurgent and the Centre is stagnant. They play

defining roles in the world's most volatile democracy.

The paranoid High Command that has been at work since 1967 has ensured the death of the regional leader with a mass base. The exit of the disillusioned regional satrap continues to be a Congress story, Bhajan Lal being the latest one to feel left out. A Congress loyalist for 27 years, he left the party when he found himself an outsider in the new power equation—and set up his own shop. Leaders like Gowda, N. Chandrababu Naidu and Banerjee were associated with the Congress at some point of time in their political career. When the High Command began taming the local leadership, victims who embodied regional grievance got the vote. During the nine years of Indira-Rajiv Gandhi rule, many Congress chief ministers were shown the door mid-term as mother and son reshuffled their cabinet 48 times. Even P.V. Narasimha Rao didn't encourage local leadership and the Congress split into three during his tenure. G.K. Moopanar floated his own Tamil Manila Congress and N.D. Tiwari launched the All India Indira Gandhi Congress (Tiwari).

If the Congress couldn't retain its regional big daddies, the Janata Dal disintegrated into half a dozen small parties led by powerful caste leaders like Ajit Singh, Lalu, Paswan and Gowda. Even BJP, which ruled the nation for over six years, couldn't stop regional resurgence. It benefited from it and captured the throne in Delhi. While retaining its middle-class Hindu vote bank, BJP encouraged regional parties to contain the Congress. Since it cannot widen its social and religious base, it keeps regional parties in good humour. Atal Bihari Vajpayee is still remembered as the author of a new coalition dharma.

With a leadership famine in the Congress and BJP, the nation is unlikely to get single party rule in the near future. A small ripple from the early '80s is turning out to be a rapacious revolution of religious and regional ideologies. It is only after 60 years of Independence that India has become a true federation of states in which various castes, religions and other identities and aspirations have

found their legitimate place in the ruling establishment. This revolution will be difficult to contain as it draws its energy from the polyphony of Indian democracy. The idea of India continues to multiply in the distant provinces of India. Its origin is regional but the impact is national—for better or worse. ■

N.T. RAMA RAO, Andhra Pradesh CM, 1989

"I do not want to let my people down. I am their man. I am not after power in the Delhi durbar."